

RISING FROM SILENCE
Patnaik addressing BJD leaders and workers at a rally in Bhubaneswar, Jan.5

ANI

At 78 years of age, most politicians might gracefully retreat from public life. But not Naveen Patnaik, Odisha's longest-serving chief minister and now leader of the Opposition in the state. The defeat in the 2024 assembly and Lok Sabha elections could well have been the epilogue to his career, but Patnaik is intent on writing a few more chapters. Exhibiting a renewed vigour, he is emerging as a vocal and dynamic political force.

CM Patnaik exuded a calm, gentlemanly demeanour in the more than two decades that he was at the helm. Opposition leader Patnaik is a sharper, feistier avatar, unafraid to take direct shots at his political rivals. The latest salvo assailed the Mohan Charan Majhi-led Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government for the rising prices, labelling it a "double engine, double blow" administration.

The clever potshot came during the Biju Janata Dal's (BJD) first major protest rally in nearly 20 years, held on January 5 near the state legislative assembly. Thousands of supporters gathered, their energy palpable as Patnaik took the stage. For a leader criticised for his detachment in his later years as CM, this marked a dramatic return to grassroots engagement, stirring public discourse. It was a clear signal that Patnaik intends to stay relevant. In that bid, he pledged to educate the two daughters of Sahadev Nayak, a sanitation worker murdered on January 8 before the 18th Pravasi Bharatiya Divas that was held in state capital Bhubaneswar.

The electoral defeat was a cataclysmic moment for the BJD. For a party that had dominated Odisha's political landscape since 2000, the loss was both shocking and humbling. Reduced to just 51 seats in the 147-member assembly, the BJD also found itself without any representation in the Lok Sabha, throwing it into an existential crisis. Defections only exacerbated the situation, as the party's Rajya Sabha presence was reduced to just seven. The absence of a second-tier leadership to carry forward Patnaik's legacy never appeared so stark. The BJP's rise was swift and aggressive, buoyed by an anti-incumbency wave and questions over the role of Patnaik's trusted aide, V.K. Pandian, whose perceived overreach had caused widespread resentment. Patnaik's reclusive attitude in his last tenure as CM did little to help matters. His health was frequently speculated upon, and his rare public appearances fuelled rumours of waning influence. Even senior party leaders struggled to meet him, while Pandian became the face of the administration.

Many saw Patnaik and his party's defeat as the end of the veteran's political journey. But the man who had turned Odisha into a model of disaster resilience and development wasn't ready to bow out just yet. His 'resurgence' began almost immediately after the election results were declared in June last year. Emerging from his chambers at Naveen Niwas, his residence in Bhubaneswar, he addressed a despondent crowd of party workers. "We have nothing to be ashamed of," he declared, earning thunderous applause. His message was clear: the fight wasn't over.

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What followed surprised both allies and opponents alike. Patnaik's influence was so undeniable that even the BJP's actions seemed to revolve around him. On December 28, just hours after Patnaik announced a visit to Ganjam—his home turf and the state's most populous district—to meet distressed farmers, the BJP scrambled to respond. That same day, a hurriedly written government